

Omega Draconis
6 Suns

Nu¹ Draconis
9 Suns

Delta Draconis
46 Suns

DRACO THE DRAGON

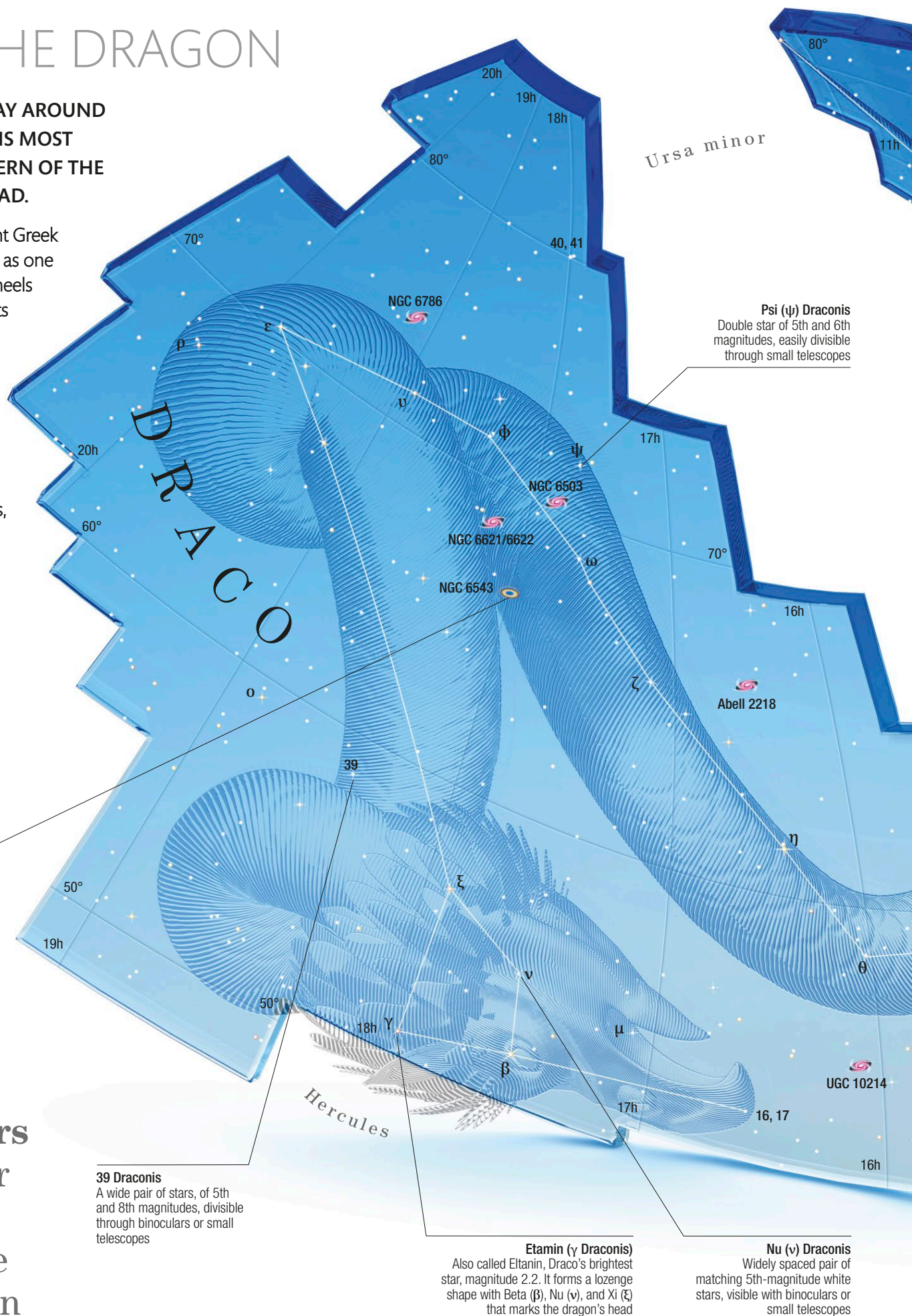
DRACO WINDS NEARLY HALFWAY AROUND THE NORTH CELESTIAL POLE. IT IS MOST EASILY IDENTIFIED BY THE PATTERN OF THE FOUR STARS THAT MARK ITS HEAD.

Draco represents the dragon of ancient Greek mythology that was killed by Hercules as one of his 12 labors. In the sky, Hercules kneels next to the dragon, with one foot on its head. Despite its large size, Draco is not a particularly prominent constellation. Its brightest star, Gamma—popularly known as Etamin or Eltanin—is of only 2nd magnitude. The constellation contains many double stars divisible by small telescopes or even binoculars, including Nu, a 5th-magnitude pair; Psi, a 5th- and 6th-magnitude pair; 16 and 17 Draconis, both of 5th magnitude; and 40 and 41 Draconis, both of 6th magnitude. Draco's comparatively few notable deep-sky objects include the Cat's Eye Nebula (NGC 6543) and the distorted spiral Tadpole Galaxy (UGC 10214).

NGC 6543

Planetary nebula, popularly known as the Cat's Eye Nebula, lying about 3,000 light-years away and visible through small telescopes as a bluish disk

Thuban was the north pole star about 3,000 years ago but is now far from the pole due to wobbling of the Earth's axis of spin



39 Draconis

A wide pair of stars, of 5th and 8th magnitudes, divisible through binoculars or small telescopes

Etamin (γ Draconis)

Also called Eltanin, Draco's brightest star, magnitude 2.2. It forms a lozenge shape with Beta (β), Nu (ν), and Xi (ξ) that marks the dragon's head

Nu (ν) Draconis

Widely spaced pair of matching 5th-magnitude white stars, visible with binoculars or small telescopes